

Session 13: The Human's Priestly Role and the Divine Command

Key Takeaways

- The description of the role of humanity in the garden, to “work and to keep” it, is priestly language, and it introduces the theme of the one who stands in the place of the many.
- God’s command concerning the two trees at the center of the garden begins with a generous invitation to enjoy the bounty of the garden.

“To Work and To Keep”: Genesis 2:15

These two verbs found in Genesis 2:15 are packed with significance, as they portray the ideal vocation of humanity. Let’s look into their meaning.

Word Study: To Work, To Serve, To Worship — *Abad* (עבד)

Exodus 20:8-10 NIV*

⁸ Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. ⁹ Six days you shall labor and do all your **‘abad**, ¹⁰ but the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God. On it you shall not do any **‘abad**, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor your animals, nor any foreigner residing in your towns.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

‘Abad = to work

Genesis 27:29 NASB*

May peoples **‘abad** you, and nations bow down to you; be master of your brothers, and may your mother’s sons bow down to you. Cursed be those who curse you, and blessed be those who bless you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

‘Abad = to serve

Exodus 3:12 NIV*

And God said, “I will be with you. And this will be the sign to you that it is I who have sent you: When you have brought the people out of Egypt, you will **‘abad** God on this mountain.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

'Abad = to worship

Numbers 18:7 NASB*

But you and your sons with you shall attend to your priesthood for everything concerning the altar and inside the veil, and you are to do your **'abodah**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Chronicles 24:3 NIV*

With the help of Zadok a descendant of Eleazar and Ahimelek a descendant of Ithamar, David separated them into divisions for their appointed order of **'abodah**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

'Abodah = priestly service

Word Study: To Keep — *Shamar* (שמר)

The phrase “to serve and keep” (*shamar* / שמר) refers to a priestly service of worship. These verbs are used together as a phrase elsewhere only in descriptions of the priests and Levites working in and around the temple.

Numbers 3:5-9 NASB*

⁵ Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying, ⁶ “Bring the tribe of Levi near and set them before Aaron the priest, that they may serve him. ⁷ They shall **shamar** the **mishmeret** for him and the **mishmeret** of the whole congregation before the tent of meeting, to **'abad** the **'abodah** of the tabernacle. ⁸ They shall also **shamar** all the furnishings of the tent of meeting, along with the duties of the sons of Israel, to **'abad** the **'abodah** of the tabernacle. ⁹ You shall thus give the Levites to Aaron and to his sons; they are wholly given to him from among the sons of Israel.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 8:26 NASB*

They may, however, assist their brothers in the tent of meeting, to **shamar** the **mishmeret**, but they themselves shall **'abad** no **'abodah**. Thus you shall deal with the Levites concerning their obligations.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 18:7 NASB*

But you and your sons with you shall **shamar** to your priesthood for everything concerning the altar and inside the veil, and you are to **'abad** the **'abodah**. I am giving you the priesthood as a bestowed service ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“עבד, to serve till’ is a very common verb and is often used of cultivating the soil (2:5; 3:23; 4:2, 12, etc.). The word is commonly used in a religious sense of serving God (e.g., Deut. 4:19), and in priestly texts,

especially of the tabernacle duties of the Levites (Num. 3:7-8; 4:23-24, 26, etc.). Similarly, מִרְשׁ 'to guard, to keep' has the simple profane sense of 'guard' (4:9; 30:31), but it is even more commonly used in legal texts of observing religious commands and duties (17:9; Lev. 18:5) and particularly of the Levitical responsibility for guarding the tabernacle from intruders (Num. 1:53; 3:7-8). It is striking that here and in the priestly law these two terms are juxtaposed (Num. 3:7-8; 8:26; 18:5-6), another pointer to the interplay of tabernacle and Eden symbolism already noted."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [*World Biblical Commentary: Vol. 1, Genesis 1-15*](#). Thomas Nelson Inc.

"[T]he tasks given to Adam are of a priestly nature: caring for sacred space. In ancient thinking, caring for sacred space was a way of upholding creation. By preserving order, non-order was held at bay ... If the priestly vocabulary in Genesis 2:15 indicates the same kind of thinking, the point of caring for sacred space should be seen as much more than landscaping or even priestly duties. Maintaining order made one a participant with God in the ongoing task of sustaining the equilibrium God had established in the cosmos. Egyptian thinking attached this not only to the role of priests as they maintained the sacred space in the temples but also to the king, whose task was 'to complete what was unfinished, and to preserve the existent, not as a status quo but in a continuing, dynamic, even revolutionary process of remodeling and improvement.' This combines the subduing and ruling of Genesis 1 with the 'bd and šmr of this chapter."

Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.

Genesis 2:16-17: The Divine Command Given About the Tree

Notice that the first command has to do with eating from all of the trees, not the prohibition of the one ([Gen. 2:16](#)). The divine command is not arbitrary and is directly linked to humanity's continued enjoyment of life in the garden of Eden.

The prohibition's purpose is to safeguard the divine intent for humanity to enjoy God's own life in the garden.

Symmetrical Pairing of the Divine Command

Genesis 2:16-17 Instructor's Translation

- a - from every tree of the garden
 - b **you will surely** eat (אכל תאכל)
- a' - and from the tree of knowing good and bad
 - b' you will not eat (לא תאכל)
- a'' - for in the day of your eating (אכלך)
 - b'' **you will surely** die (מות תמות)

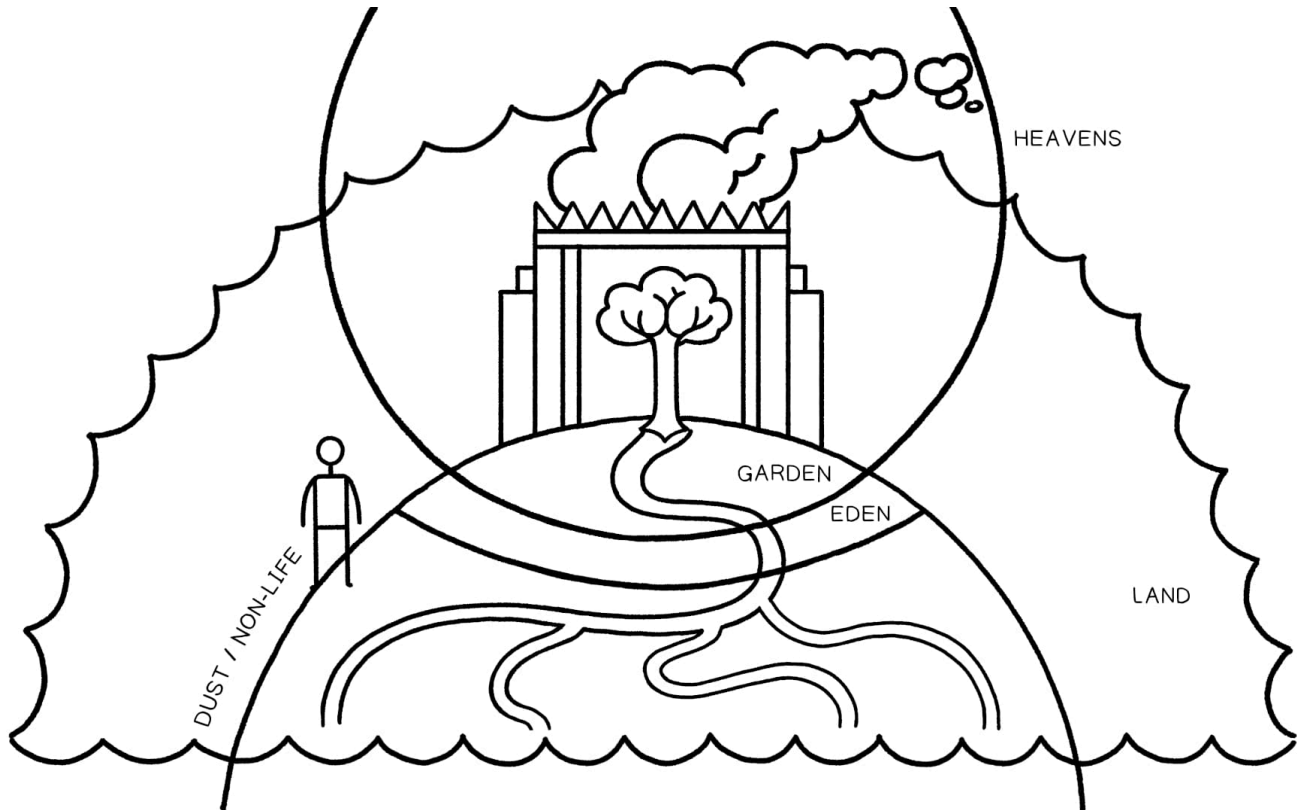
Magical Fruit?

The divine command does not assume that the fruit has magical powers to give knowledge. Rather, the choice to eat is itself the act of "knowing good and bad."

“No fruit per se is magically conveying life or death; it is the eating from one or the other tree that brings about life or death, that is, the choice to strike a path independent of divine wisdom.”

LaCocque, Andre (2012). [*The Trial of Innocence: Adam, Eve, and the Yahwist*](#). Wipf and Stock.

When the humans eat the fruit, they cut themselves off from the source of life—exile is death in this scenario. It is not immediately clear in chapter 2 what it means to die after eating the forbidden fruit. However, it becomes clear at the end of chapter 3 as the humans are banished from the garden.



Exile As Death Outside of Eden. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reflection Question

What is the very first command God gives to humanity in the garden?